FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

So the "semi-finals" have given us an unambiguous answer, with the Narendra Modi juggernaut devouring the landscape as usual. The clean sweep of the three heartland states was so emphatic, it belies the fact the BJP victory came against the odds. Its scale and how it was crafted methodically, both top-down and bottom-up, make a big statement. One topic of contention has been how much predictive power these assembly polls have vis-a-vis the 2024 general election. The common sense was that there's no automatic translation, no guarantee that one result will determine the other. The caveat came in 2018, when the Congress won Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh, and it still got a drubbing in 2019. Does that caveat still hold? Not quite the same way. Momentum is an undeniable element in politics. The Congress itself got its consolation in the South via a triumphant revival in Telangana because of momentum from its Karnataka victory this summer. The BJP's victory in the North carries that kind of voltage surge, an X-factor that entails but exceeds common sense.

Against what could have been a more cautious judgement on a dodgy pitch, the prime minister took the risk of making these polls about himself. Instead of leaving it to the satraps, even at the risk of diminishing them, he put his own chariot out front. In contrast to the BJP's command-and-control style, the Congress deviated from its playbook and decentralised, giving its satraps a near-carte blanche. This was more necessity than charity: its weaker high command could not stand up to its errant and often vain regional grandees. Its ambition of portraying itself as the prime challenger to Modi in the North stands deflated: these three states account for 65 Lok Sabha seats, over one-third of the 186 where the Congress will be in a one-to-one fight with the BJP. Demonstrating its rival's insipid strike rate here, the BJP defangs a key Opposition strategy for 2024.



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This came about with Modi personally going up against the likes of Bhupesh Baghel, Ashok Gehlot and Kamal Nath. A daring strategy, and not without the risk that comes with exposing oneself in open battle, but he pulled it off. And by indirectly taking on and deflecting a host of issues the Opposition has been raising against the Centre, it helps blunt their edge on wider turf. He neutralised the issue of the caste census, supposedly the trump card of the INDIA alliance, judging by the overwhelming pro-BJP vote by the OBCs. That seems like a mini-referendum on Modi himself. A third term for him looks an even more tangible prospect than before, something not seen in India since Nehru, and rare even on the world stage.

The BJP truly excels in getting all the tiny details to fall in line to create a hurrah effect, to create a whole larger than the parts. In our main cover story this week, Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa, along with Deputy Editor Anilesh S. Mahajan, looks ahead at how the BJP plans to carry that forward, strategising for 2024 based on these results, plugging the gaps, sewing up more regional and caste micro-alliances to tie up loose ends, never resting on its laurels. Ground stories from MP, Chhattisgarh, Rajasthan and Telangana by Senior Associate Editor Rahul Noronha in Bhopal/Raipur, Deputy Editor Rohit Parihar in Jaipur and Senior Deputy Editor Amarnath K. Menon in Hyderabad flesh out the picture from below. Besides Lalduhoma's mould-breaking triumph in Mizoram, Executive Editor Kaushik Deka assesses the situation for the Congress. It now re-enters confabulations with the INDIA bloc considerably chastened, assuaging annoyed partners who are none too pleased with its conduct and performance in the assembly polls.

The story is anchored in exhaustive and fascinating data from the Axis My India team. The BJP has pulled off impressive vote shares: a truly Modiesque 48.55 per cent in MP, a massive 46.27 per cent in Chhattisgarh and 41.7 per cent even in Rajasthan, where the Modi-First strategy was the diciest. But in its hour of misery, the Congress is seeking solace from the fact it has held its ground in vote shares despite its seat shares bottoming out. In MP, it holds firm at 40.40 per cent, compared to 40.89 per cent in 2018. In Chhattisgarh, it scored 42.23 per cent (2018: 43.04 per cent) and in Rajasthan, it even improved to 39.5 per cent (from 39.3 per cent). The BJP succeeded because of clever micro-managing at the constituency level.

Dissect the patterns within this, and it tells you crucial facts: why the OBC vote was key and how segments created through economic handouts can override social identity. Firstly, the lustre of Brand Modi has not dimmed one bit in the core zones. The typical urban, educated privileged castes are solidly with it, while it radiates outward to novel constituencies: take the 7 percentage point surge in women voting BJP owing to Chouhan's Ladli Behna Yojana.

The BJP was able to achieve this big victory by consolidating its vote amongst traditionally loyal communities, while splitting the vote among communities that have traditionally sided with the Congress. In MP, for example, the BJP netted 57 per cent of the OBC vote whereas the Congress got only 32 per cent, 59 per cent of the general category votes (Congress 31 per cent) and 60 per cent of the Brahmin vote (Congress 29 per cent). The vote share gap among voters who typically side with the BJP was around 30 percentage points. But among typically pro-Congress communities, the contest was much tighter. Among Dalits, the gap was only 2 percentage points (Congress 44 per cent, BJP 42 per cent) and among tribals, the Congress's lead is a meagre 1 percentage point (45 per cent, to BJP's 44 per cent). Variations of this played out in the other two heartland states.

The Congress returns once more to the drawing board with a long, glum face. It must be kicking itself in the foot for not bagging at least Chhattisgarh, where it seemed the most comfortable. It now rules only three states. The entry of cash-rich Telangana to that list will bring cheer. It shows that planning, a good narrative and a strong face such as Revanth Reddy can displace even a formidable presence such as KCR.

But the really formidable presence looms in the hallways of Lutyens' Delhi. And that presence does not rest on his laurels for a minute. Having crippled the Opposition, he's now all set to establish his footprint across the country in the 2024 general election.



(Aroon Purie)